

How Does Child Neglect Affect Emotional and Cognitive Development in Children?

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Introduction

Child neglect, one of the most prevalent and damaging forms of abuse, is often overlooked compared to physical and sexual abuse. However, its consequences can be just as severe, frequently leading to lasting developmental and emotional harm. Hildyard and Wolfe (2002) define neglect as the omission of necessary care for a child's healthy development, particularly in emotional nurturing, supervision, and nutrition. The effects of neglect are profound, often resulting in developmental delays, emotional disturbances, and permanent social and emotional damage.

Neglect is a widespread issue. Sedlak and Broadhurst (1996) found that in the United States, neglect is the most common form of child maltreatment, affecting approximately 30 out of every 1,000 children (Hildyard & Wolfe, 2002). Jellen et al. (2001) and Kaplan et al. (1999) note that emotional neglect—often the hardest to detect and most frequently overlooked—has seen an increase in reported cases in recent years (Hildyard & Wolfe, 2002). Unlike physical abuse, neglect usually arises not from isolated incidents but from persistent failures to meet a child's basic needs, often due to ongoing family problems or societal issues such as poverty, mental illness, and substance abuse (Hildyard & Wolfe, 2002). Addressing neglect is crucial, as it can have long-lasting consequences on children's cognitive and emotional development. This raises the research question: To what extent does neglect affect emotional and cognitive development in children in the U.S.?

Literature Review

Risk Factors and Causes of Neglect

Child neglect can result from individual, familial, and environmental factors.

Avdibegović and Brkić (2020) categorize these causes into three models: the parental deficit model, the environmental deficit model, and the ecological-transactional model. Cameron et al. (2007) explain that the parental deficit model suggests neglect occurs when caregivers fail to meet a child's needs due to mental illness, substance abuse, or inadequate parenting skills (Avdibegović & Brkić, 2020). In this view, neglect is primarily a consequence of a parent's inability to cope with the stresses of parenting.

The environmental deficit model focuses on factors such as poverty and material deprivation, suggesting that financial instability and lack of resources make it difficult for parents to provide adequate care. Poverty can limit access to essential resources like medical care and nutritious food, which are critical for a child's development. Lastly, the ecological-transactional model integrates both individual and environmental factors, proposing that stressors from financial instability and unsafe living conditions can lead to mental illness or substance abuse, increasing the risk of neglect (Avdibegović & Brkić, 2020). These models help explain the factors that contribute to a higher risk of neglect.

In many cases, neglect stems from parental burnout. Mikolajczak et al. (2018) note that "almost all of the burnt-out parents we have met and interviewed reported sleep disorders." Parents often work long hours to provide for their children, reducing the amount of sleep they can get. This connects to the ecological-transactional model, in which environmental and individual stressors affect a parent's ability to provide care. Sleep deprivation increases stress,

emotional exhaustion, and impaired caregiving, reducing a parent's ability to meet a child's emotional and physical needs. Mikolajczak et al. (2018) highlight that burnt-out parents often feel “as tired on waking as control people do before going to bed,” making it more likely they may engage in neglectful or even abusive behaviors.

Types of Neglect

Neglect can take various forms, including physical neglect, emotional neglect, and educational neglect. Physical neglect involves failing to provide basic needs such as food, housing, and medical care. Emotional neglect occurs when a child lacks emotional support, which can be more difficult to identify but equally harmful. Educational neglect arises when children are denied opportunities to attend school or learn. Additionally, Avdibegović and Brkić (2020) describe parental supervision neglect, where children are left vulnerable to harm, and parents fail to protect them from unsafe environments. This may include exposure to substance abuse, violence, or poor living conditions. Often, these forms of neglect overlap, compounding the harm and leading to more severe consequences.

Impact on Child Development

Neglect has profound effects on a child's physical, emotional, and social development. Perry (2002) and Cicchetti (2002) found that neglect during critical stages of early childhood can disrupt brain development, cognitive abilities, emotional regulation, and social interactions (Avdibegović & Brkić, 2020). Early childhood is a sensitive period for brain development, and experiences during this time have lasting effects. Neglected children often have smaller brains, particularly in areas related to emotional regulation and executive function (Hildyard & Wolfe,

2002), which can impair their ability to form healthy relationships, regulate emotions, and navigate social situations.

Widom et al. (2007) found that neglect increases vulnerability to mental health disorders, substance abuse, and relationship difficulties (Hildyard & Wolfe, 2002). Neglected children have a higher risk of developing conditions such as depression, anxiety, and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). Emotional neglect, in particular, can reduce trust, making it difficult to form meaningful connections and leading to social marginalization.

Neglect can also be life-threatening. Berkowitz (2001) reports that 30–40% of child deaths from abuse result from neglect, with the majority occurring in children under two years old (Scannapieco & Connell-Carrick, 2002). These statistics underscore the urgent need for intervention and preventive measures.

Barriers to Addressing Neglect

Addressing neglect presents many challenges. One major issue is underreporting, particularly of emotional neglect, which is harder to detect than other forms of abuse. Neglect often involves omissions rather than direct acts of harm, making it difficult for educators, health professionals, or social workers to identify. Additionally, children experiencing neglect often face systemic issues, such as poverty, substance abuse, or domestic violence, which can make it harder for them to express their struggles. Environmental stressors may prevent parents from providing proper care, even if they are willing and caring.

Societal stigma also discourages parents from seeking help. There is a misconception that neglect reflects a parent's moral failure, leading to judgment from society. Many parents feel

ashamed of their inability to manage stress or provide sufficient care, which can make them reluctant to access support services. Often, neglect stems from environmental factors outside of a parent's control, yet stigma hinders families from obtaining the resources they need to prevent or address neglect.

Prevention and Intervention

Prevention programs targeting families facing financial stress, parental burnout, or substance abuse can provide essential resources, strengthen parenting skills, and offer education on stress management. Counseling and therapy services should be accessible to families experiencing burnout, addressing one of the leading causes of neglect. Increased awareness of free childcare services and organizations like UNICEF can also help children who lack access to resources due to environmental factors. By implementing these solutions, it can create safer, more supportive environments for families, reducing the risk of neglect and its long-term consequences on children's emotional, social, and physical development.

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